newfound status as States with greater sovereignty, if not complete independence from the Holy Roman Empire, European States were at greater liberty to assert and develop their respective ‘national identities’ based on ethnicity, language and religious denomination as well as to pursue their respective religious, economic and political goals. The freedom from the vice-like grip of the Roman Catholic Church allowed the people to develop a closer connection with their States and their national identities, paving the way for greater crystallisation of nation-statehood and the beginnings of European nationalism.

In addition, since these States saw themselves as defenders of the Christian faith owing to the loss of the Habsburg Empire’s monopoly over *the* faith, they developed their own competitive ‘national systems of morality’ within and drawing from Christian OET, and set their sights on acquiring greater resources to further their respective competing visions. Therefore, while Columbus’ expedition began in 1492 and colonisation by the Spaniards and the Portuguese had already taken root, the creation of sovereign States by the Westphalian Peace meant that there were more European States in the fray who now competed for the resources of the New World. Consequently, it came as no surprise that the new States followed the Spanish and the Portuguese policies of establishing colonies with papal benedictions.

This spurred on the race for competitive nationalism and colonialism while remaining firmly within the Christian fold, a point which needs to be emphasised given the excruciatingly embarrassing contemporary tendency to secularise history. There is sufficient basis to conclude that these States were driven by inter-denominational competitiveness, triggered by the Protestant Reformation and the Peace of Westphalia. The New World or the non-Christian world became the battleground for this aggressive rivalry for wealth, territory, resources and ultimately, national cum denominational supremacy.

These zealous colonising ventures of the European States were funded by wealthy aristocrats in alliance with the ruling elite to preserve their positions within the States as well as to benefit from the expansionist colonising vision of the ‘Christian secular’ monarchs. That the alliance between wealthy aristocrats and the governing class gave rise to mercantilism, nationalism and, perhaps, nationalistic mercantilism would not be an unsubstantiated statement to make.[20] Some scholars believe that